

Research Interests

I am broadly interested in systems research, with an emphasis on confidential computing, operating systems, and emerging hardware architectures. The central theme of my current work is to employ a hardware-software co-design approach to develop secure systems that scale well and are resilient to failures.

Education

- 2021–Present **Ph.D.**, *Technical University of Munich*, Munich, Germany.
◦ Expected graduation: 2026
◦ Advisor: Prof. Pramod Bhatotia
- 2020–2021 **Master of Science by Research**, *The University of Edinburgh*, Edinburgh, UK.
◦ Computer Science
◦ Advisors: Prof. Pramod Bhatotia, Prof. Antonio Barbalace
- 2015–2019 **Bachelor of Technology**, *Indian Institute of Technology (IIT) Dhanbad*, Dhanbad, India.
◦ Electronics and Communication Engineering

Publications

Breaking the Rack Barrier with Jigsaw: A Hardware-Software Co-Design for Transparent, DMA-Coherent Accelerator Disaggregation

Harshavardhan Unnibhavi, Maximillian Jäcklein, Atsushi Koshiba, Masanori Misono, Pramod Bhatotia.
(Under Submission at EuroSys '27)

IronBus: A Decentralized Trusted Bus for Accelerators

Harshavardhan Unnibhavi, Julian Pritzi, Atsushi Koshiba, Nuno Santos, Pramod Bhatotia.
(Under Submission at MICRO '26)

Guardian: Policy-Compliant AI Agents

Teofil Bodea, Masanori Misono, Julian Pritzi, Patrick Sabanic, Thore Sommer, **Harshavardhan Unnibhavi**, David Schall, Nuno Santos, Dimitrios Stavrakakis, Pramod Bhatotia.
(Under Submission at CCS '26)

OSDI'26 μ Shell: A Microkernel-based FPGA Shell Architecture

Jiyang Chen, Anubhav Panda, **Harshavardhan Unnibhavi**, Atsushi Koshiba, Pramod Bhatotia

CCS'26 GDPRuler: A Trusted GDPR Monitor for Cloud Data Systems

Dimitrios Stavrakakis, Masanori Misono, Julian Pritzi, **Harshavardhan Unnibhavi**, Nuno Santos, Pramod Bhatotia.

ATC'24 vFPIO: A Virtual I/O Abstraction for FPGA-accelerated I/O Devices.

Jiyang Chen, **Harshavardhan Unnibhavi**, Atsushi Koshiba, Pramod Bhatotia.

SIGMOD'22 Secure and Policy-Compliant Query Processing on Heterogeneous Computational Storage Architectures.

Harshavardhan Unnibhavi, David Cerdeira, Antonio Barbalace, Nuno Santos and Pramod Bhatotia.

EuroSys'22 VMSH: Hypervisor-agnostic Guest Overlays for VMs.

Jörg Thalheim, Peter Okelmann, **Harshavardhan Unnibhavi**, Redha Gouicem and Pramod Bhatotia.

EuroSys'21 Rkt-io: a direct I/O stack for shielded execution.

Jörg Thalheim, **Harshavardhan Unnibhavi**, Christian Priebe, Pramod Bhatotia, and Peter Pietzuch.

Work Experience

- 2026–Present **Google**, *Student Researcher*, Remote.
◦ Mentors: Dr. Behnam Montazeri, Dr. Arjun Singhvi
- 2025 **Google**, *Software Engineering Intern*, Sunnyvale, USA.
◦ Mentors: Dr. Behnam Montazeri, Dr. Arjun Singhvi
- 2024 **Intel Labs**, *Research Intern*, Munich, Germany.
◦ Mentors: Dr. Dmitrii Kuvaiskii, Mona Vij

- 2021 **Google Summer of Code (GSoC)**, *QEMU*, Remote.
 - Mentors: Stefano Garzarella, Fabiano Fidêncio
- 2019 **Indian Institute of Science**, *Research Assistant*, Bengaluru, India.
 - Mentor: Prof. Yogesh Simmhan
- 2018 **Simon Fraser University**, *Research Assistant*, Burnaby, Canada.
 - Mentor: Prof. Ivan V. Bajic

Talks

- 2024 **ATC '24**, *vFPIO: A Virtual I/O Abstraction for FPGA-accelerated I/O Devices*.
- 2022 **SIGMOD '22**, *IronSafe: A Secure and Policy-Compliant Query Processing Architecture*.
- 2022 **MSR Cambridge**, *IronSafe: A Secure and Policy-Compliant Query Processing Architecture*.
 - Host: Dr. Kapil Vaswani
- 2021 **Redhat**, *Development of a vhost-user-vsock application*.
 - Host: Stefano Garzarella

Service

IEEE S&P 2027, *Program Committee Member*.
Euro S&P 2026 Posters, *Program Committee Member*.
ASPLOS 2026 AEC, *Program Committee Member*.

Research Experience

- 2024–Present **Disaggregated Acceleration**, TU Munich.
 We are designing a HW/OS co-designed system to enable pooling accelerators over the network without requiring any modifications to existing software stacks and hardware devices.
- 2024 **Cloud deployment of Gramine-TDX**, Intel Labs.
 In this project, we designed a framework to enable applications (parent VMs) to offload security-sensitive tasks to confidential VMs running Gramine-TDX. We explored ways to provide access to I/O within the confidential VM over a minimal communication interface with the parent VM.
- 2023 **Virtual I/O Abstractions for FPGA-accelerated I/O**, TU Munich.
 In this project, we designed an FPGA hardware shell that abstracts away the heterogeneity amongst the IO devices on an FPGA by providing simple and efficient to use abstractions and interfaces. This allows developers to concentrate solely on their acceleration logic by offloading the handling of IO devices to our shell.
- 2022–Present **Hardware/OS Co-design for Trusted Acceleration**, TU Munich.
 We are designing a layered system stack that enables applications to securely use accelerators for their computations and obtain proofs of the same. The stack consists of programming libraries and interfaces, and an OS kernel that is co-designed with trusted hardware extensions.
- 2021–2022 **Shells for lightweight VMs**, TU Munich.
 This project enables one to attach to and run services and tools on a virtual machine at runtime. This enables the VM to be as lightweight as possible while providing the ability to extend its functionality at runtime.
- 2020–2021 **Secure and policy-compliant query processing on heterogeneous architectures**, TU Munich.
 This project presents IronSafe, which allows applications to offload query processing operations to computational storage devices in a secure manner and obtain proofs of the same. We explored ways to extend the trust domain from the heterogeneous host to a storage device.
- 2020–2021 **Direct I/O stacks for shielded execution**, University of Edinburgh.
 In this project, we designed a direct IO stack atop a library OS to allow applications to safely access IO devices from within a TEE. We explored ways to reduce the attack surface by minimizing interactions with the host OS while maintaining full POSIX compatibility.

Awards and Honors

- 2022 EuroSys'22 Best Artifact Award (Honorable Mention)
- 2018 Mitacs Globalink Fellowship
- 2015 KVPY Fellowship
- 2013 NTSE Fellowship

Teaching

- 2023 Introduction to Software Engineering
- 2023 Cloud Software Engineering
- 2022 Cloud Systems Engineering
- 2021 Practical lab: Swiss-knife for Computer System Systems
- 2021 Practical lab: Advanced Systems Programming in C/Rust

Research Advising

PhD

- 2023-2025 Jiyang Chen: FPGA-accelerated I/O

Master's

- 2023 Julian Pritzi: Securing Hardware Communication using Encryption and Attestation

Undergraduate

- 2023 Maximilian Jäcklein: Protecting H/W and S/W Interactions for Network-Attached Accelerators
- 2023 Jonas Zöschg: End-to-End On-Chip Encryption to Prevent Physical Attacks
- 2022 Julian Pritzi: An in-hardware cycle-accurate benchmarking tool for security critical operations

Technical Skills

- Areas Operating Systems, Virtualization, Computer Architecture, Confidential Computing
- Languages Verilog, Rust, C, Python, C++
- Tools Vivado, Vivado HLS, Vitis, QEMU, KVM, gem5

References

Prof. Pramod Bhatotia,
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INESC-ID Lisbon,
nuno.m.santos@tecnico.ulisboa.pt.